



No more excuses

别再找借口了

难度评级：★★★★☆

Plunging test scores are a slow-moving catastrophe

考试成绩大幅下滑，一场慢性灾难正在上演

【 Para.1 】

Schools in RICH countries are failing. The latest scores on PISA tests of reading, maths and science, released on September 8th, are the worst since the tests, **administered** by the OECD, began in 2000. Educators can no longer blame it all on covid-19 **lockdowns**, which badly messed up lessons and caused PISA grades to drop. The pandemic is now over, but scores have continued to fall roughly as fast. In 35 rich countries that take part in the tests, a typical 15-year-old now reads no better than a 14-year-old did a decade ago. A slow-motion disaster is under way.

富裕国家的学校正在走向失败。9月8日公布的最新一轮 PISA（国际学生评估项目）阅读、数学与科学测试成绩，创下自2000年该项考试（由经合组织 OECD 负责实施）开考以来的最差纪录。教育工作者再也无

文章导读：

富裕国家学生成绩持续下滑。成绩并非孩子的全部，却是预示人生好坏的重要指标。质疑：AI 时代，孩子不再刻苦学习也无妨？反驳：AI 无法替代思维训练，学校的责任反而更重。成绩下滑原因之一：屏幕分散注意力，限制使用势在必行。更深层问题：教育界的混乱思维与低期待。对策：增拨经费收效甚微，教育研究亟待加强。英国等国的逆势回升印证传统教学之效。改革见效慢、政治阻力大，忽视教育终将招致灾祸。

plunge v. /plʌndʒ/ to fall suddenly and quickly from a high level or position 骤降，暴跌；纵身投入【考研大纲词汇】

The stock market **plunged** by 8% in a single day.
股市单日暴跌8%。

administer v. /əd'mɪnɪstə(r)/ to manage and organize the affairs of a company, an organization, etc. 管理，执行；主持（考试）【考研大纲词汇】

The test is **administered** by an independent agency.
该考试由一家独立机构主持。

lockdown n. /'lɒkdaʊn/ an official order to control the movement of people, especially in an emergency 封锁，禁闭（措施）

Millions of children fell behind during the pandemic **lockdowns**. 疫情期间的封锁让数百万儿童学业落后。

predictor n. /pri'dɪktə(r)/ a sign or fact that shows what will happen in the future 预测指标，预示因素

Early reading ability is a strong **predictor** of later academic success. 早期阅读能力是日后学业成功的有力预测指标。

bulwark n. /'bʊlwɜ:k/ a person or thing that protects or defends something 堡垒，屏障，保障

A good education is a **bulwark** against poverty.
良好的教育是抵御贫困的屏障。

deviation n. /,di:vi'eɪʃn/ the act of moving away from what is normal or acceptable 偏离，偏差【考研大纲词汇】

The scores **varied** widely, with a standard **deviation** of 15 points. 分数差异很大，标准差为15分。

outsource v. /'aʊtsɔ:s/ to arrange for work to be done by another company or person 外包，把.....交给外部处理

Many firms **outsource** their customer service to call centres abroad. 许多公司把客服外包给海外呼叫中心。

法把这一切都归咎于新冠封锁——它曾严重扰乱课堂教学，导致 PISA 成绩下滑。如今疫情早已结束，但分数仍在以大致相同的速度继续下跌。在参加测试的 35 个富裕国家中，如今一名普通 15 岁学生的阅读水平还比不上 10 年前 14 岁学生的水平。一场“慢动作式”的灾难正在上演。

【 Para.2 】

Test scores are not the full measure of a child. But they are a good **predictor** of desirable outcomes and a **bulwark** against many of the worst ones. Kids who do well on tests tend to earn more, live longer and healthier lives, and commit fewer crimes. By one estimate, pushing up PISA scores by a mere quarter of a standard **deviation** might increase annual growth in rich countries by half a percentage point.

考试成绩并非衡量一个孩子的全部标准。但它们却是预判未来良性发展的良好指标，也是抵御诸多糟糕人生际遇的坚实屏障。考试表现优异的孩子往往收入更高、活得更久更健康，犯罪率也更低。据一项估算，只要把 PISA 成绩提高区区四分之一一个标准差，就能让富裕国家的年度经济增长率提升半个百分点。

【 Para.3 】

Perhaps, though, as artificial intelligence improves, the fact that children struggle intellectually will not matter so much? The adults of the future will be able to **outsource** their thinking to clever machines, just as they use machines to perform innumerable physical tasks. So why **sweat** about **swotting**?

sweat v. /swet/ to be very anxious or worried about something; to produce sweat 焦虑，担心；出汗【考研英语词汇】

Don't **sweat** the small stuff — focus on what matters.

别为琐事焦虑，专注于要紧的事。

swot v. /swɒt/ (BrE, informal) to study very hard, especially in order to prepare for an exam (尤指为应考) 刻苦学习，死用功

He's **swotting** for his final exams this week.

他这周正在为期末考试拼命复习。

agility n. /əˈdʒɪləti/ the ability to move or think quickly and easily 敏捷，灵活，机敏

Mental **agility** is increasingly valued in the modern workplace. 现代职场越来越看重思维敏捷。

temptation n. /tempˈteɪʃn/ the desire to do or have something, especially something wrong or unwise 诱惑，引诱【考研英语词汇】

I resisted the **temptation** to check my phone during the lecture. 我克制住了上课期间看手机的冲动。

divert v. /daɪˈvɜːt/ to make somebody/something change direction or purpose 转移，使转向【考研英语词汇】

Social media **diverts** young people's attention away from their studies. 社交媒体转移了年轻人对学业的注意力。

instil v. /ɪnˈstɪl/ to gradually make somebody feel, think or behave in a particular way 逐渐灌输，培养（品质、能力）

Parents should **instil** good habits in their children from an early age. 父母应该从小培养孩子的好习惯。

prudent adj. /ˈpruːdnt/ sensible and careful when you make judgements and decisions 谨慎的，明智的【考研英语词汇】

It would be **prudent** to save some money for emergencies. 存些钱以备不时之需是明智的。

snazzy adj. /ˈsnæzi/ fashionable, bright and modern, and attracting your attention 漂亮而时髦的；吸引人的

SYN jazzy, smart

a **snazzy** tie 漂亮的领带

muddle-headed adj. /ˈmʌdl ˈhedɪd/ confused; not thinking clearly 头脑混乱的，糊涂的

Muddle-headed policies have done more harm than good. 头脑混乱的政策弊大于利。

canard n. /ˈkænɑːd/ a false report or story that people spread deliberately 谣言，虚假报道

The claim that exams harm children is a **canard**.

"考试有害"的说法纯属谣言。

warp v. /wɔːp/ to become or make something become bent or twisted; to change behaviour in a negative way 使变形，使扭曲【考研英语词汇】

Years of criticism had **warped** her confidence.

多年的批评扭曲了她的自信。

不过，也许随着人工智能不断进步，孩子们学习吃力这件事，也就不那么重要了？未来的成年人将能够把思考"外包"给智能的机器，正如他们借助机器来完成数不清的体力劳动一样。那么，何必还要为埋头苦读伤脑筋呢？

【 Para.4 】

This argument could not be more wrong. AI will not make it pointless to train human brains, any more than the invention of cars eliminated the need for physical exercise.

On the contrary, adapting to a world of rapid, AI-driven change will require more mental **agility**, not less. And precisely because AI will increase the **temptation** for people to outsource difficult cognitive tasks, schools have an extra duty to help pupils exercise their brains and acquire the hard habits of thinking. Failure to furnish them with the basic building blocks of a well-developed mind, such as literacy and numeracy, is inexcusable.

这种论点错得离谱。AI 并不会让训练人类大脑变得毫无意义，正如汽车的发明并没有消除锻炼身体的需要一样。恰恰相反，要适应一个人工智能驱动的快速变化的世界，我们需要的是更高的思维敏捷度，而非更低。而且，正因为 AI 会加剧人们把复杂认知任务"外包"出去的诱惑，学校更有责任帮助学生锻炼大脑、养成刻苦钻研的习惯。若不能为孩子们提供健全心智的基石——比如读写能力和计算能力——那是不可原谅的。

【 Para.5 】

PISA scores began drifting downwards around 2012. The

shovel v. /'ʃʌvl/ to put large amounts of something somewhere quickly 大量投入，大把地塞

Shovelling more money at the problem will not solve it. 向这个问题大量砸钱并不能解决它。

boost n. /bu:st/ an increase in something; something that helps or encourages 推动，促进，提升【考研英语大纲词汇】

The tax cut gave a big **boost** to consumer spending. 减税大大推动了消费支出。

radical adj. /'rædɪkl/ in favour of complete social or political change; very new and different 激进的，彻底的【考研英语大纲词汇】

The university's education department is known for its **radical** views. 这所大学的教育学院以观点激进著称。

scrape v. /skreɪp/ to manage to succeed or pass with great difficulty 勉强获得，艰难达到【考研英语大纲词汇】

The team **scraped** into the finals by a single point. 该队以一分之差勉强挤进决赛。

rigorous adj. /'rɪgərəs/ done carefully and with great attention to detail; strict 严格的，严谨的【考研英语大纲词汇】

Rigorous testing is essential before a new drug can be approved. 新药获批准前必须经过严格的测试。

inspection n. /ɪn'spekʃn/ an official visit to check that rules are being obeyed 检查，视察，督导【考研英语大纲词汇】

The school passed its annual **inspection** with flying colours. 这所学校以优异成绩通过了年度督导检查。

curriculum n. /kə' rɪkjələm/ the subjects that are taught in a school, college, etc. 课程，全部课程【考研英语大纲词汇】

The national **curriculum** includes compulsory maths and science. 国家课程包含必修的数学和科学。

jiffy n. /'dʒɪfi/ a very short time 一会儿，瞬间

I'll be back in a **jiffy**. 我马上就回来。

lag n. /læɡ/ a period of time between one event and another 滞后，延迟【考研英语大纲词汇】

There is often a time **lag** between a policy decision and its results. 政策决定与其效果之间往往存在时间滞后。

calamity n. /kə' læməti/ a serious accident or disaster 灾难，祸患【考研英语大纲词汇】

Ignoring the warning signs would invite **calamity**. 忽视警示信号将会招致灾难。

dim adj. /dɪm/ not bright; (of a person) not intelligent 昏暗的；愚钝的【考研英语大纲词汇】

The future looks **dim** for those who drop out of school. 辍学者前途黯淡。

evidence is growing that tablets, mobile phones and other such screens are distracting youngsters from their studies and **diverting** them from hobbies, like reading books, that **instil** the ability to focus. So limits on screens seem **prudent**. About half of countries now ban mobile phones from schools to some extent; more should follow. Used carefully, technology can benefit classrooms. More usually, **snazzy** new tools and devices just get in the way.

PISA 成绩大约从2012年开始逐渐下滑。越来越多的证据表明，平板电脑、手机和其他此类屏幕正在分散青少年对学业的注意力，使他们远离阅读书籍等能培养专注能力的爱好。因此，限制屏幕使用时间似乎是明智之举。目前大约有一半的国家在一定程度上禁止在学校使用手机；更多国家应该效仿。若使用得当，技术能让课堂受益。但更常见的情况是，花哨的新工具和新设备只会带来妨碍。

【 Para.6 】

An even bigger problem, though, is **muddle-headed** thinking among educators. Some have fallen for the leftist **canard** that tests are harmful and grades are racist. Some have allowed reasonable worries about children's mental health to **warp** into an excuse for low expectations. Some unhelpful habits acquired during the pandemic have stuck: children are still missing more lessons than before, and many teachers who relaxed their grading standards have failed to tighten up again.

然而，更大的问题在于教育工作者自身思路混乱。一些人听信了左翼的谬论，认为考试有害、分数带有种族主义色彩。一些人将对孩子心理健康的合理担忧，

► 今日句子分析

主句

AI will not make it pointless to train human brains,

主语 谓语 形式宾语 宾补 真正宾语 (不定式短语)

比较状语从句 (not... any more than...)

any more than the invention of cars eliminated the need for

比较连词 主语 谓语 宾语
physical exercise.

在主句中：

主语：AI； 谓语：will not make； 形式宾语：it；

宾补：pointless； 真正宾语：to train human brains；

在比较状语从句中：

比较连词：any more than；

主语：the invention of cars；

谓语：eliminated； 宾语：the need for physical exercise.

本句的核心是 not... any more than... 结构，意为“不……正如……也不……”，是考研英语中的高频考点，用于将两件事物进行类比否定。主句主干为 AI will not make it pointless to train human brains：其中 it 为形式宾语，真正宾语是后面的不定式短语 to train human brains，pointless 为宾语补足语，整个结构意为“AI 不会使训练人类大脑这件事变得毫无意义”；any more than 引导比较状语从句，与主句的 not 呼应，从句主干为 the invention of cars eliminated the need for physical exercise，其中 the need for physical exercise 为“名词+介词”搭配。翻译时需将“not... any more than...”这一类比否定结构完整译出，可译为“……并不会……，正如……也没有……”，既保留原句的论证力度，又符合中文的表达习惯。

► 写作积累

Para 2. But they are a good predictor of desirable outcomes and a bulwark against many of the worst ones.

a bulwark against —— 抵御……的堡垒；……的坚实屏障；bulwark 本义为“堡垒、防波堤”，引申为“起保护或防御作用的人或事物”，常与 against 连用，构成 a bulwark against sth 的固定搭配，强调抵御某种风险、威胁或不良结果。相比 protection against 或 defence against，bulwark 更加正式、更具画面感，常用于论述教育、制度、法律等对风险的防护作用。例如：The rule of law is a bulwark against tyranny. (法治是抵御暴政的堡垒。) 在写作中，a bulwark against 可用于论证“某事物能有效防范某危害”，增强论点的分量。

Para 5. More usually, snazzy new tools and devices just get in the way. get in the way —— 碍事，妨碍，挡道，主语通常是事物而非人，强调某物阻碍了正常的进程或目标的实现，与 hinder、obstruct

扭曲成了降低要求的借口。一些疫情期间养成的不良习惯仍然存在：学生缺课比以往更多，许多放宽了评分标准的教师也未能重新严格起来。

【 Para.7 】

What to do? There is little evidence that **shovelling** more cash into schools will make much difference: Japan spends 30% less per pupil than America and gets much better results. But research needs a big **boost**. Teaching, as a profession, remains shamefully uninterested in the evidence about which techniques work best. Education departments in universities contain some of the weakest and most **radical** staff, often keener on abstract ideas of social justice than the more concrete benefits that better grades might bring to pupils.

该怎么办？几乎没有证据表明向学校大量投入资金就能产生明显效果：日本每个学生的教育支出比美国低30%，却取得了好得多的成绩。但研究亟需大力加强。今人汗颜的是，教学这一行业仍对有关哪种教学方法最为有效的证据漠不关心。大学里的教育院系聚集着一些能力薄弱、理念激进的教职人员，他们往往更热衷于抽象的社会正义理念，而不是更好的成绩可能给学生带来的更具体的益处。

【 Para.8 】

Places that have avoided declines deserve more attention. Britain is one. In 2009 its pupils **scraped** into the world's top 30 in maths and reading. Now

同义，但更加形象化。本文用它说明花哨的新科技产品非但无益于课堂，反而妨碍教学，语言生动而犀利。在写作中，get in the way 常用于批评性论述，例如：Over-engineering can get in the way of simple solutions.（过度设计反而会妨碍简单方案的实施。）使用时注意其主语常为抽象事物或工具，而非人。

they sit in the top ten. Some of this stems from a return in England, under a previous Conservative government, to old-fashioned things such as **rigorous** exams, tough **inspections** and fact-filled **curriculums**.

那些成绩没有出现下滑的地区值得更多关注。英国就是其中之一。2009年，英国学生的数学与阅读成绩勉强挤进世界前30名。如今他们位居前十。其中部分原因在于，英格兰在前保守党政府执政时期，重拾一系列传统举措，例如严格考试、严厉督导以及重视基础知识的课程体系。

【 Para.9 】

Falling scores will not be fixed in a **jiffy**. Because it takes time to educate a child, the latest test results bear the marks of decisions taken ten to 20 years ago. That long **lag** makes reform politically harder. Governments that make schools better will seldom see benefits they can boast about before the next election. But they should care anyway. Politicians in past decades, from Tony Blair to George Bush, have won office promising to fix education. Today's leaders seem to have cooled on schools, except as culture-war battlegrounds. That lack of serious attention invites **calamity**. As machines grow brighter, don't let teenagers grow any **dimmer**.

解决成绩下滑的问题，无法一蹴而就。因为教育一个孩子需要时间，最新的考试结果折射出10～20年前各项决策留下的印记。这种漫长的滞后使得教育改革在政治层面步履维艰。改善学校教育的政府，很少能在下届大选前收获可供炫耀的政绩。但政府仍然应当予以重视。过去几十年的政

客们，从托尼·布莱尔到乔治·布什，都曾以承诺改革教育而赢得大选。如今的领导人似乎对学校兴趣索然，除非是把学校当作文化战争的战场。这种缺乏认真关注的态度将招致灾祸。随着机器变得越来越聪明，切莫让青少年变得越来越迟钝。